still alive in the collective memory of millions. Boatloads of villagers row across from villages far and near, their women softly singing traditional songs passed down through generations. It is a moment of eternity. The sun reflects off the ramparts built by a Muslim emperor who grew to understand this. A short walk away is the spot, marked by a column, where a global power was forced to acknowledge this ancient civilization in order to legitimize its rule.

The column commemorating the Queen's Proclamation is a short walk from Saraswati Ghat and stands neglected in an overgrown park. None of the locals seemed to know the significance of the place. This is unfortunate because the modern Indian State is the direct outcome of this Proclamation. After independence, the government capped the column with a replica of the national emblem, the Mauryan lions and the wheel. Usually I disapprove of meddling with the artifacts of history, but somehow it seemed appropriate that the dreams of Sudasa and the Mauryas are remembered at that place.

Although colonial expansion became less overt after 1858, a large gap remained between the Indians and their British rulers. The separation is visible even in urban planning. British towns were clearly segregated into the spacious 'white-towns' and crowded 'black-towns'. It is not unusual for rulers to live separately from the ruled. We see this in both the citadel of Dholavira as well as the Red Fort of Shahjehanabad. However, the elites still lived within the same cultural context as the wider population. In contrast, there was a large cultural gap between the spacious bungalows of the Civil Lines and the bazaars of the indigenous population.

Nowhere was this more visible than in the Civil Lines of Allahabad itself. The fifty years following the Revolt would be the heyday of Empire. The British considered themselves superior to the rest of humanity and were grudgingly acknowledged as such. It would be many decades before a trickle of Indians, armed with a Western education, would be reluctantly allowed into this world. Till as recently as 2005, vestiges of this era were clearly visible in the large, crumbling bungalows of Allahabad's Civil Lines. However, when I revisited it in April 2012, I found that the